PODIUM — field research pack

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Print this or keep it on your phone. It is a list of things only a person standing in a room can find out. Every AI answer you have so far rests on assumptions that you are about to replace with facts.

The one job today

Go to Aspire Fitness. Measure the corner. Ask the owner what they would pay.

Everything else on this list is secondary. Three independent analyses of your business all reached the same conclusion: **members paying R20 a session does not pay for a pod.** The model only works if a gym pays you a monthly fee.

Nobody has ever asked a gym whether they would. That is today's job, and you are the only one who can do it.

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1. Measure the space — before you buy anything

The camera needs about **2.6 m** between the lens and the person, or you cut off their head and feet. That is not negotiable; it is how lenses work. So the first question is whether Aspire has a corner that deep.

Take a tape measure. Fill this in:

Measurement	Why it matters	Your number
Depth of the corner (wall to open floor)	Need ≥ 3.2 m total	
Width available	Need ≥ 2.5 m	
Ceiling height	Light stand is 2.6 m; need clearance	
Distance to nearest plug socket	Extension lead length	
Number of plug sockets within reach	Light + laptop + screen	
Windows in or near the corner?	Sunlight moves; it will ruin consistency	
Mirrors behind or beside?	Reflections ruin the shot	
Overhead lights directly above?	They leak into the frame	
What is in that corner now?	What the gym gives up	

Then do this: stand in the corner, hold your phone where the camera would go, and walk backwards until a person fits head to toe in the frame. Measure that distance. That is your real number, and it beats anything calculated.

Photograph the corner from where the camera will sit, and from the door. You will need these for the 3D design tomorrow.

2. Measure the light

Download a free **light meter app** (search "lux meter"). It costs nothing and it answers a question no AI can.

Reading	When	Your number
Lux in the corner, lights on, curtains open	Morning	
Lux in the corner, same, afternoon	Afternoon	
Lux at the brightest point of the gym	Any time	
Lux in the corner with gym lights off (if possible)	Any time	

What you are looking for: a big difference between morning and afternoon means sunlight is reaching that corner, and your photographs will never match between visits. If that is true, you need a different corner or a roof on the bay. Better to find out today than in week three.

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3. The conversation with the gym owner

This is the most valuable twenty minutes of your weekend. Do not sell. Ask.

Questions, in this order:

1. What does a square metre of your floor earn you? *(If they won't say: how much do you charge per month for a personal trainer to use a space?)*
2. What do you currently spend on member retention — apps, challenges, InBody scans, anything?
3. Have you ever paid a monthly fee for equipment or a service that was meant to keep members? What was it, and what did it cost?
4. If this demonstrably kept even two members a year who would otherwise have left, what would that be worth to you per month?
5. Would you rather: pay nothing and let members pay me directly; pay a monthly fee and let members use it free; or split it?
6. What would make you say no to this entirely?

Write down the actual numbers they say. Not your impression of them.

Then ask the question that decides it: *"If the four weeks show that people come back, would you pay R1,500 a month for it?"* Watch the face, not just the answer.

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4. The shopping list

Total about **R7,000**. Order matters — buy top to bottom and stop when the money runs out.

#	Item	Where	Expect to pay	What you paid
1	Godox SL60W COB light	CameraStuff (JHB, 2–4 days) or a Cape Town camera shop	R3,400	
2	Godox SB-FW35160 strip softbox (35×160cm)	Same	R1,330	
3	Light stand, 260cm, air-cushioned	Same	R700	
4	Blackout fabric, 5m × 2.8m	raglandfabrics.com	R650 + R145 delivery	
5	Floor tape (heavy duty, black)	Builders	R100	
6	White foam board / polystyrene sheet (reflector)	Builders	R150	
7	Hooks, curtain wire, clamps	Builders	R400	
8	18% grey card	Camera shop	R150	
9	Surge-protected extension lead	Builders / Makro	R200	

Phone a Cape Town camera shop first — Orms, Cameraland, Kameraz. If they have the Godox in stock you can build today instead of waiting for delivery from Johannesburg. Ask for the price including VAT.

What to check at the counter

- **The light:** does it have a **digital power readout** (a number you can write down and set again), or just a knob? A knob is useless to you — you need the same light every single visit. Ask to see it switched on.
- **CRI number:** ask. You want **93 or higher**. If they don't know, ask to see the box.
- **The stand:** what weight is it rated for? Light plus softbox is about 3 kg. A 3 kg stand is not enough.
- **The fabric:** hold it up to the shop lights. If light comes through, it is not blackout.

Do not buy today

A scale. A mini PC. A new webcam. An enclosure. A second light. Anything branded. All three reports agree: these wait until the pilot answers whether people come back.

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5. Production costs — the research only you can do

For the real pod later, you need local quotes. AI estimates for fabrication are guesses. Phone these people and ask:

Aluminium extrusion suppliers (Cape Town):

- Price per metre for 40×40 T-slot extrusion
- Do they cut to length? What does cutting cost?
- Brackets and fixings — price per corner

Shopfitters / metal fabricators (Stellenbosch, Somerset West, Cape Town):

- Hourly rate
- Rough quote to build a 2.5 × 1.5 × 2.2 m freestanding frame with panels
- Rough quote for the same at 5 units
- Lead time

Ask every one of them the same question: *"If I brought you a drawing, what would you need on it to give me a firm price?"* That tells you exactly what tomorrow's 3D design has to contain.

Supplier	Type	Phone	Rate / quote	Lead time

6. The numbers that decide everything

So you know why you are doing all this.

- **Break-even on a production pod:** about **5.4 paid sessions a day at R20**. Your pilot target is 4 a day. **You are below break-even at your own target.**
- **At 4 sessions a day**, a R65,000 pod takes around **56 months** to pay back. It will not last that long.
- **With a gym paying R1,500/month**, payback drops to about **21 months** on a production pod, **10 months** on a pilot-grade one.
- **Kill number:** if fewer than **30%** of first-timers come back within the four weeks, it is a photo booth, not a progress tool. Stop building pods.

- **R20 is probably too cheap.** Evolt charges R250–R920 a scan. InBody is R350. DQ Fitness in Somerset West lists R300, or R899 for four scans. People already pay real money for body measurement.

If you want to test a higher price, decide before the pilot starts. The software now records your thresholds when you press Start and flags any later change, because sessions at R20 and sessions at R40 are not the same measurement. One price, four weeks.

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7. For tomorrow — what the 3D design needs

Your father is right that a drawing should come before a prototype. For it to be worth anything, it needs the numbers you collect today:

- The real corner dimensions from section 1
- The real camera distance you measured by walking backwards
- The ceiling height
- Where the power is
- What the fabricators said they need on a drawing

Without those, a 3D model is decoration. With them, it is a quote request.

Today's checklist

- [ ] Measure the corner at Aspire — all nine measurements
- [ ] Walk backwards with your phone; find the real camera distance
- [ ] Photograph the corner from two angles
- [ ] Lux readings, morning and afternoon
- [ ] Talk to the gym owner — all six questions, write the numbers down
- [ ] Phone a Cape Town camera shop for Godox stock and price
- [ ] Buy items 1–9 if the money is there, in that order
- [ ] Phone two fabricators and one extrusion supplier
- [ ] Bring the numbers back

Nothing on this page can be done by an AI. That is why it is your list.